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ACTOR PART BOOK

# The Son

*the one who will not act*

*Six Characters in Search of an Author*

*Sei personaggi in cerca d'autore · Pirandello, trans. Storer 1922*

A Village Players production · Lausanne

Director: **Kiarash Jamshidi**

**38 SPEECHES · 759 WORDS ACROSS THE PLAY**

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## WHO THE SON IS

Twenty-two, tall, severe — at the edge of his own family as if he had walked onto the stage against his will, which in fact he did. The refuser. He calls himself *an unrealised character*, never given dramatic life by his author and refusing to ask for it now — yet he is on the stage, indissolubly bound to the chain. Play him quiet, cold, with the energy of someone who would leave if he could. Every line is a door closing.

He is the production's most modern figure: the adult child who has been told he must show up for a parent's narrative and has decided *no*. The audience recognises him before they can name what they recognise. He keeps his hands in his pockets. He turns away from the Mother before she finishes speaking to him. He never looks at the Boy-chair or at the Child-bundle — they belong to a family he refuses to be the brother of. He looks at the floor, at the wall, at the wings; never at the Manager unless he has to. Stage him to be unmoveable, not still. There is a difference, and the actor must find it.

It is essential the actor understands: **he is the only Character who agrees with the author who abandoned them**. When the Step-Daughter says the author refused to stage the drama out of disgust for the ordinary theatre, the Son speaks — for the only time in the play — in agreement with another voice: *Exactly what it was, sir; exactly that*. He does not want this staged either. He is on the side of art, not on the side of the family drama. His refusal is not stubbornness; it is not coldness. It is an aesthetic and ethical position. He will not allow his life to be made into theatre. That is what makes him modern. That is what makes him dangerous.

His mirror speech in Act Three — his likeness thrown back as a horrible grimace — is the only moment he allows himself a real cry. The fountain narration at the very end of the play is the only continuous sentence he gives the room. Both are wounds he tried to keep closed and could not. Make each one count. Until those two moments, every line he speaks is a door closing.

## THE PLAY, AND HOW IT BEGINS

**What it is.** Pirandello's *Six Characters in Search of an Author* (1921). A theatre company's ordinary rehearsal is interrupted by six figures — a Father, a Mother, a Step-Daughter, a Son, and two silent children — who claim to be unfinished Characters, abandoned by their author, and demand that their drama be staged. The evening is the collision between their fixed, unbearable story and a working company's attempt to turn it into theatre.

**This production.** Set in Lausanne, played by **nine live performers** with **two stage objects** in place of the two youngest children (a coat-and-chair for the Boy, a wrapped bundle for the Child), on three stripped settings — **no projection, no screen**. One interval, after Act One; the second half plays unbroken to the fountain.

**How it opens.** The curtain is already up on a half-lit working stage. The Village Players are dragging themselves into a rehearsal of another Pirandello play, *Mixing It Up* — the Manager arrives tired and behind, there is the business of the cook's cap, the Players bicker. Then the working lights soften to a strange amber: the Door-keeper carries in the Boy-chair, and the four family Characters walk on, the Step-Daughter already holding the Child-bundle. From that entrance the play has begun, and it does not let go.

## HOW TO READ THIS BOOK

Everything this role says and does, in performance order, grouped by act and by part. Each speech is preceded by a short **CUE** — the tail of the line before it — so you can find your entrance. Where the role doubles a function, the function is printed beside the line (*as Prompter*, and so on); chorus lines the company speaks together keep their group tag (*All Three Players*). Blocking lives in the bracketed action cues inside the speeches. The text is pulled byte-for-byte from the Director's Copy, so it always matches the current script.

# Act One — The Family

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## PART I *The Rehearsal*

THE SON DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

*THE SON* (22) tall, severe in his attitude of contempt for *THE FATHER*, supercilious and indifferent to *THE MOTHER*. He looks as if he had come on the stage against his will.

## PART II *The Interruption*

12 SPEECHES · 277 WORDS

**CUE** *The Manager*: Let's hear them out. Listen!

**THE SON**. Oh yes, you're going to hear a fine bit now. He will talk to you of the Demon of Experiment.

**CUE** *The Father*: ... account of this expression which I have found to excuse myself with.

**THE SON** [*without looking up*]. Yes. Phrases. Phrases.

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: ... lay down for me, gentlemen — and I two months an orphan.

**THE SON** [*to the STEP-DAUGHTER*]. This is vile.

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: ... manteaux. The pretext is always robes. The arrangement is always something else.

**THE SON**. And he thinks he bought the right to tyrannize over us with that hundred francs. Which — note this, gentlemen — he never got the chance to pay.

**CUE** *The Manager*: A bit discursive this, you know!

**THE SON** [*turning his face away from the FATHER*]. Literature. Literature.

**CUE** *Player 2*: Pardon — did we just witness a confession?

**THE SON** [*the Father, cornered, has turned to his son — and the room's eyes follow. The Son keeps his hands in his pockets, body not moving*]. Don't look at me. I don't come into this.

**CUE** *The Father*: What? You don't come into this?

**THE SON**. I've got nothing to do with it. And I don't want to have. You know perfectly well I wasn't made to be mixed up in all this with the rest of you.

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: ... lower his eyes — because he knows what he did to me.

**THE SON** [*scarcely looking at her*]. I?

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter*: ... is his mother too. And I came as mistress of the house.

**THE SON**. It's easy for them to put me always in the wrong. One day, gentlemen, a young woman of impudent bearing arrives at my home, asking for my father. Then she returns, bolder, with that child there — and asks him for money, in a way that lets one suppose he *must* give it. Must. Because he has every obligation.

**CUE** *The Father*: ... I have, in fact, this obligation. I owe it to your mother.

**THE SON.** How should I know? When had I ever seen or heard of her? One day there arrive with her [*Indicating Step-Daughter.*] that lad and this baby here. I am told: "This is your mother. Also." I divine from her manner why they have come home. I had rather not say what I feel about it. I shouldn't even care to confess it to myself. No action can therefore be hoped for from me in this affair. Believe me, sir — I am an "unrealised" character. Leave me out of it, I beg you.

| **CUE** *The Father:* What? It is just because you are so that...

**THE SON.** How do you know what I am like? When did you ever *bother your head* about me?

| **CUE** *The Son:* ... I am like? When did you ever bother your head about me?

**THE SON** [*the one time the cold cracks*]. You all need me because somebody must be guilty who did nothing.

### **PART III**    *The Bargain*

THE SON DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

# Act Two — The Theatre

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## PART I *The Setup*

2 SPEECHES · 132 WORDS

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* Ouff! what's the good, if you've arranged everything.

**THE SON** *[looking at the three entering office].* Oh this is fine. Fine. And to think I can't even get away. *[The MOTHER attempts to look at him, but lowers her eyes immediately when he turns away from her. She then sits down. She gathers the Child-bundle into her lap and draws the Boy-chair close beside her. She casts a glance again at the SON, and speaks with humble tones, trying to draw him into conversation.]*

*The SON turns away before the word is finished. She stops where she is; the unfinished word stays in the air between them. After a moment she sits again, and holds the Child-bundle a little lower, as though it had grown heavier in her arms.*

**CUE** *The Mother:* My son —

**THE SON** *[half to himself, meaning the MOTHER to hear — eyes on the floor].* And they want to put it on the stage. If there was at least a reason for it. He thinks he has got at the meaning of it all. Just as if each one of us, in every circumstance of life, couldn't find his own explanation of it. *[Pauses.]* He complains he was discovered in a place where he ought not to have been seen, in a moment of his life that should have stayed hidden. And what about my case? Haven't I had to reveal what no son ought ever to reveal — how father and mother live, and are man and wife, for themselves — quite apart from that idea of father and mother which we give them?

## PART II *The Apparition*

THE SON DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

*The MOTHER, who watches the progress of the scene with THE SON beside her, the Child-bundle held tight in her arms and the Boy-chair pulled in against her knee, is on thorns; and follows with varying expressions of sorrow, indignation, anxiety, and horror the words and actions of the other two. From time to time she hides her face in her hands and sobs.*

## PART III *The Substitution*

THE SON DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

# Act Three — The Question

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## PART I *The Trap*

THE SON DOES NOT SPEAK IN THIS PART.

## PART II *The Refusal*

7 SPEECHES · 69 WORDS

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... for the ordinary theatre as the public knows it and likes it.

**THE SON** *[looking up, for once — directly at the Manager].* Exactly what it was, sir. Exactly that.

**CUE** *The Father:* ... much, and of this young man, who won't do anything at all.

**THE SON.** No, nothing!

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... as that fellow there is here... You must send him away first.

**THE SON** *[jumping up].* Delighted! Delighted! I don't ask for anything better. *[Begins to move away.]*

**CUE** *The Manager:* No! No! Where are you going? Wait a bit!

**THE SON** *[to MANAGER who stops him].* I've got nothing to do with this affair. Let me go please! Let me go!

**CUE** *The Father:* ... has to act the terrible scene in the garden with his mother.

**THE SON** *[the body finally still — a kind of dignity arrives].* I will act *nothing* at all. I've said so from the very beginning. *[To the MANAGER.]* Let me go.

**CUE** *The Step-Daughter:* ... him that... There, you see? She is willing to act her part.

**THE SON** *[trapped now — and knowing it].* No. No. If I can't go away, then I'll stop here. But I repeat. I act nothing.

**CUE** *The Father:* You can force him, sir.

**THE SON.** Nobody can force me.

## PART III *The Fountain*

17 SPEECHES · 281 WORDS

**CUE** *The Manager:* Yes, yes of course; that's it. Both at the same time.

**THE SON** *[to MANAGER].* What do you mean by both at the same time? It isn't right. There was no scene between me and her. *[Indicates the MOTHER.]* Ask her how it was!

**CUE** *The Mother:* Yes, it's true. I had come into his room...

**THE SON.** Into *my* room. Do you understand? Not the garden. Nothing about this ever happened in the garden.

**CUE** *The Manager:* ... doesn't matter. Haven't I told you we've got to group the action?

**THE SON** *[observing the JUVENILE LEAD studying him].* What do you want?

**CUE** *Player 3:* Nothing! I was just looking at you.

**THE SON** *[turning towards the SECOND LADY LEAD].* Ah! she's at it too: to re-act her part! *[Indicating the MOTHER.]*

**CUE** *The Manager:* ... to me that you should be grateful to them for their interest.

**THE SON** *[the cry he has been holding for the whole production — surprising himself].* Yes — but haven't you yet seen that it isn't possible to live in front of a mirror? One that doesn't simply hold your face, but throws it back at you — twisted into a grimace.

**CUE** *The Manager:* He's right! Move away from them!

**THE SON.** Do as you like. I'm out of this!

**CUE** *The Mother:* ... have inside me. All of it. But the moment he saw me...

**THE SON.** Nothing happened! There was no scene. I went away, that's all! I don't care for scenes!

**CUE** *The Father:* You'll do this for your mother, for your mother, do you understand?

**THE SON** *[flat].* I do nothing.

**CUE** *The Father:* ... a favor? Haven't you even got the guts to be a son?

**THE SON** *[taking hold of the FATHER].* No! No! And for God's sake stop it, or else... *[General agitation.]*

**CUE** *The Father:* You've got to obey, do you hear?

**THE SON** *[the voice cracking but the body refusing the cry].* What does it mean — this madness you've got? *[They separate.]* Have you no decency — that you would show the whole world our shame? I won't do it. I won't. The author who made us could not bear to stage this. Neither will I.

**CUE** *The Manager:* Man alive! You came here...

**THE SON** *[indicating FATHER].* He did! I didn't!

**CUE** *The Manager:* Aren't you here now?

**THE SON.** It was his wish, and he dragged us along with him. He's told you not only the things that did happen, but also things that have never happened at all.

**CUE** *The Manager:* ... did happen. You went out of your room without saying a word?

**THE SON.** Without a word, so as to avoid a scene!

**CUE** *The Manager:* And then what did you do?

**THE SON.** Nothing... walking in the garden... *[Hesitates for a moment with expression of gloom.]*

**CUE** *The Manager:* Well, well... walking in the garden...

**THE SON** *[exasperated].* Why on earth do you insist? It's horrible! *[The MOTHER's arms are empty — the Child-bundle is no longer in them, and she is the first in the room to feel its absence. Her hands close on nothing. She trembles, sobs, and looks towards the fountain before anyone has said why.]*

**CUE** *The Manager:* The baby?

**THE SON.** There in the fountain...

**CUE** *The Manager:* And then you...



**THE SON** *[the only continuous sentence he gives the room; he tells it because he cannot keep it inside any longer].* I ran over to her. I was jumping in — to drag her out — when I saw something that stopped me where I stood. The boy. Standing stock still. With a look on his face I will never forget. Watching his little sister, there in the water. *[The STEP-DAUGHTER bends over the basin and lowers the Child-bundle into it. The basin's walls hide the action from view. She sobs.]* **Then...** *[The fountain light holds for ten seconds on the silhouette of the Boy-chair behind the basin — the Boy watching. Then full blackout. Out of the dark, a revolver shot rings out from behind the basin where the Boy-chair is.]*

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*Village Players · Lausanne · The Son part book · lines and actions pulled from the Director's Copy.*